

Linux. DeepRoot's Web-based software uses the Perl and Catalyst Web framework while the systems software is a mix of C, Perl and Bash.

Sound business strategy

DeepRoot has a strong business model based on charging for the services it provides. "If anything goes wrong with your free software, we'll fix it, regardless of whether we developed it or not—but for a price. The revenue generated by selling our services around Linux has made us profitable for the last four years. Today, we have around 400 such regular customers," says Abhas.

To successfully implement this business strategy and ensure that awareness translates into adoption, the company focuses on marketing and strong advocacy. "We now have a dedicated team for sales and marketing. We also actively advocate FOSS via content, campaigns, etc, because awareness alone will transform this sellers' market into a buyers' market."

The hurdles

Though DeepRoot has been able to arrive at a profitable business model, timely payments from clients and procuring funding from banks for future projects still remain a challenge.

Nevertheless, DeepRoot has overcome its initial challenge of developing a team. "Today, we no longer have a talent crunch as we have found developers committed to working on free software," says Abhas, who will again be on the hunt for talent when DeepRoot expands its business.

DeepRoot—the route to promising careers

DeepRoot Linux provides long-term and full-time careers to developers, and believes that such software businesses offer promising career opportunities. But what skillsets do they look for? "Knowledge and a long-term commitment to free software is all that is needed to pursue a full-time career in free software," says Abhas.

Advising developers looking for a full-time career in free software, Abhas suggests two options: "Many companies do use free software in their products without announcing it. Such companies can be a gateway to free software job opportunities for developers. Further, companies still unaware of the potential of FOSS can also provide a challenging and long-term opportunity for free software developers. They can become the agents for change—to go beyond just preaching the values of FOSS and come up with actual free software solutions for enabling the business." Whatever the route to a career in free software, Abhas believes one has to remain committed to FOSS and embrace more people into the FOSS community.

FOSS business opportunities abound

DeepRoot has shown the business opportunities that free software offers for an entrepreneur. "Because

Factsheet

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we chose the free software business route, as a business we had a greater ability to take risks and lower experimentation costs. Decision making and addressing problems was also easier and faster as the developer community would come out with solutions that were beyond the reach of the DeepRoot team," says Abhas, who believes a lot more of the business opportunities around free software still need to be explored by entrepreneurs.

Talking about the business potential of FOSS, he says, "FOSS has tremendous business opportunities as first, many sectors like SMEs cannot afford proprietary software and second, a lot of the software problems in India are very local. They are related to the way we run businesses in India and thus, need locally-developed solutions. We see FOSS solutions and services for the Indian consumer as a hot area for us, or any entrepreneur looking at free software business. If you can address the local problem, you are sure to rise."

But explore the area with caution, advises Abhas. "Focus on building FOSS products and not Web services because, although the returns are better now, services around FOSS products are more promising in the long run. Second, don't hold back software. Release it as fast as possible as it is in everyone's interest—specially in the interest of your business."

The path ahead

Looking ahead, Abhas says, "Our next line of products will be a direct challenge to software-as-a-service, which locks in the customer. We hope to offer SaaS-like services using FOSS and then deliver them on to local networks." Alongside, DeepRoot aims to remain committed to solving problems, especially with regard to Indian businesses. 

By: Vanisha Joseph

The author loves to experiment and writing for LINUX For You is her latest experiment. So, beware! Just a minute, she also happens to be a journalist during the day.